

Setting Speed Records

The 1920s was a great era for racing and record breaking, with contests like the Schneider Trophy for seaplanes really capturing public interest. An international contest, it was won by Italian, British, and American aircraft in the 1920s and racing definitely improved the breed. Reginald Mitchell's Supermarine racers clearly inspired the Spitfire; while in the US Alfred Verville built the first fighter monoplane with a retractable undercarriage.

▷ Verville-Sperry R-3 1922

Origin USA

Engine 443 hp Curtiss D12 water-cooled V12 (earlier, 300 hp Wright H3)

Top speed 233 mph (375 km/h)

Alfred Verville's streamlined cantilever-wing monoplane racer was even fitted with fully retractable landing gear. Three were built, contesting the Pulitzer Prize from 1922 to 1924, when it won.



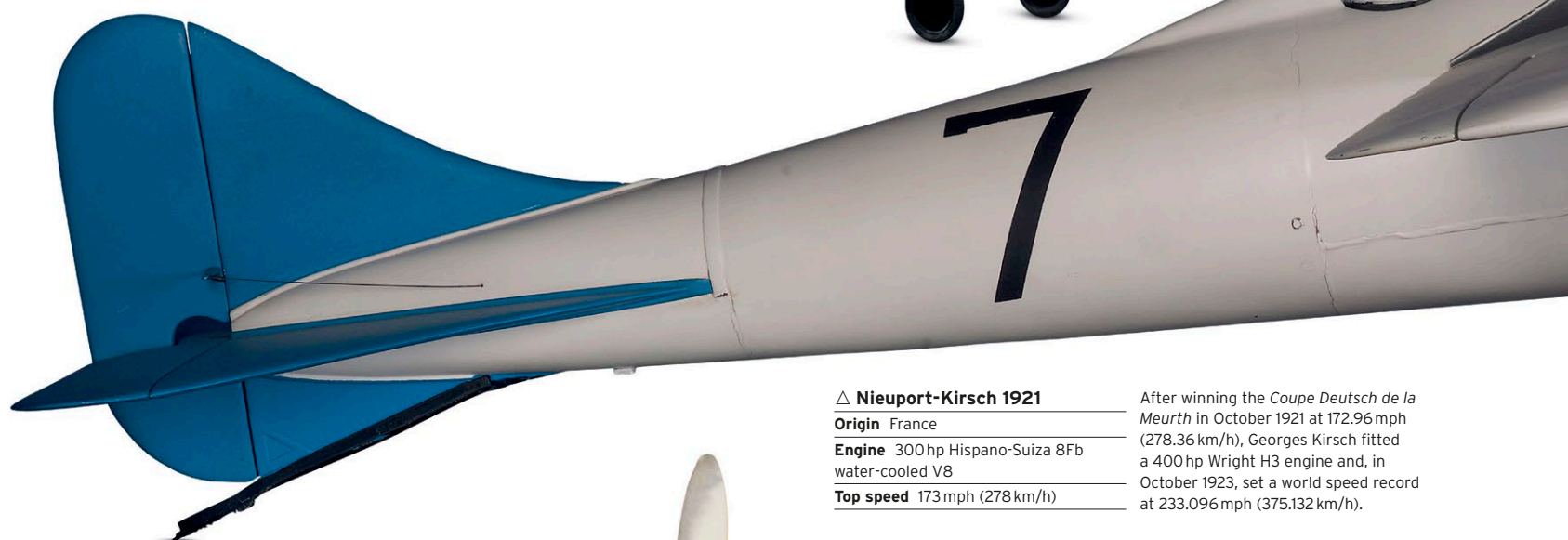
▷ Gloster Bamel/Mars I 1921

Origin UK

Engine 450 hp Napier Lion II water-cooled Broad Arrow

Top speed 212 mph (341 km/h)

Designed by Henry Folland based on his Nieuport Nighthawk fighter, Mars I (or Bamel) was modified to reduce drag, setting a British speed record of 212.15 mph (341.42 km/h), just above the world record.



△ Nieuport-Kirsch 1921

Origin France

Engine 300 hp Hispano-Suiza 8Fb water-cooled V8

Top speed 173 mph (278 km/h)

After winning the *Coupe Deutsch de la Meurth* in October 1921 at 172.96 mph (278.36 km/h), Georges Kirsch fitted a 400 hp Wright H3 engine and, in October 1923, set a world speed record at 233.096 mph (375.132 km/h).



△ Supermarine Sea Lion II 1922

Origin UK

Engine 450 hp Napier Lion II water-cooled Broad Arrow

Top speed 160 mph (258 km/h)

Supermarine modified its Sea King fighter to contest the 1922 Schneider Trophy, fitting a Napier Lion engine for the race. Despite its bulky appearance, it won at 145.7 mph (234.48 km/h), flown by Henri Biard.



△ Supermarine S6A 1928

Origin UK

Engine 1,900 hp Rolls-Royce R supercharged water-cooled V12

Top speed 329 mph (529 km/h)

For 1928 Reginald Mitchell refined his superb S5, swapping the 900 hp Napier Lion engine for a 1,900 hp Rolls-Royce unit, adding extra radiators in the floats. H. R. D. Waghorn won, at 328.63 mph (528.88 km/h).

▷ Supermarine S5 1927

Origin UK

Engine 900 hp Napier Lion VIIA water-cooled Broad Arrow

Top speed 320 mph (514 km/h)

Brilliant designer R. J. Mitchell built an all-metal semimonocoque for the 1927 Schneider Trophy race. Napier Lion-engined, it looked right—and was. Lt. S. N. Webster won the race at 281.66 mph (453.28 km/h).

